
The Ten Scrolls

An overview of the spirit, refrain, and principles of each scroll in The Greatest Salesman in the World by Og Mandino

Prepared for Optimum • A companion to the book, not a substitute for it

Optimum

HEALTH | LIFE | RETIREMENT

Own Your Future

How to use this

The scrolls are meant to be read in order, one at a time, three times a day for thirty days each. Each is built around a single line repeated throughout the chapter. That repetition is deliberate: the goal is to turn the idea into a reflex rather than a memory. The summaries below capture the heading, the refrain, the spirit of the chapter, its core principles, and one way to put it into practice.

The scrolls, in order

Scroll I Building the Habit

Scroll II Leading With Love

Scroll III Persistence

Scroll IV You Are Unique

Scroll V Urgency

Scroll VI Emotional Control

Scroll VII Laughter and Perspective

Scroll VIII Multiplying Your Value

Scroll IX Action

Scroll X Guidance and Humility

Scroll I

BUILDING THE HABIT

REFRAIN

Today I begin a new life.

THE SPIRIT OF IT

The first scroll is the on-ramp for everything that follows. Its central claim is that people fail not because they lack talent but because they are run by bad habits, and that the only real work is to replace those habits with good ones. The scroll then makes its own reading ritual the first habit: read it morning, midday, and night for thirty days before moving on. The repetition is not decoration. It is the mechanism by which a new way of thinking is installed.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- Habits, not circumstances, decide outcomes. Change the habits and the results follow.
- Old patterns are overwritten by repetition, not by willpower or a single decision.
- The past no longer has a vote. Yesterday's failures are set down and left behind.
- Discipline in the small daily ritual is the proof that the larger change is real.

IN PRACTICE

Pick one daily practice and protect it for thirty days before adding anything else. Consistency in the small thing is the whole point.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** Tell the people close to you what habit you are changing, and let them hold you to it. Accountability is a form of love.
- **In sales.** Build one non-negotiable daily block for prospecting and treat it like an appointment with your best client.
- **In leadership.** Model the ritual before you ask for it. A team copies what the leader does at 8:30, not what the leader says about it.

Scroll II

LEADING WITH LOVE

REFRAIN

I will greet this day with love in my heart.

THE SPIRIT OF IT

This scroll argues that love is the most practical tool a person has, because it is the one force other people cannot defend against. Criticism and pressure create resistance; genuine warmth dissolves it. The scroll works through how to extend that warmth outward to every person met, inward to oneself, and to the day itself, regardless of what it brings. It reframes love not as a feeling to wait for but as a decision to make each morning.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- Warmth disarms. People open up to those who make them feel valued.
- Look for what is good in every person and speak it out loud.
- Treat enemies, critics, and difficult people with the same regard as friends. Hostility only feeds hostility.
- Self-respect comes first. Someone who does not value themselves cannot offer real value to others.

IN PRACTICE

Before every call or meeting, decide in advance to like the person you are about to talk to. It changes your tone, and they can hear it.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** Lead every conversation at home with appreciation before correction. People change faster when they feel valued first.
- **In sales.** Compliment something real about the client in the first minute. Warmth opens the door that a pitch cannot.
- **In leadership.** Catch people doing things right in public and coach them in private. Warmth is what makes hard feedback land.

Scroll III

PERSISTENCE

REFRAIN

I will persist until I succeed.

THE SPIRIT OF IT

The most quoted scroll in the book, and the one most people remember. Its argument is simple: rejection and failure are not verdicts, they are steps. Every no moves you closer to a yes. Every setback is information. The scroll uses images of water wearing away stone and small blows felling a large tree to make the point that success is rarely a single act and almost always an accumulation. The only real failure is stopping.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- Rejection is part of the process, not a judgment on your worth.
- Try one more time. The next attempt is always the one that matters.
- Never let a bad day become a bad week. Each day resets.
- Do not measure success by the last result; measure it by whether you kept going.
- Learn from those who have already done it, and from your own missteps.

IN PRACTICE

Count attempts, not outcomes. When a day goes badly, the assignment is not to fix everything, it is to make one more call.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** When someone you love pulls away, keep showing up. Steady presence outlasts almost any rough patch.
- **In sales.** Track your dials and your follow-ups, not your closes. The numbers you control are the ones that produce the ones you don't.
- **In leadership.** Stay in the trenches with new agents through their first slump. Most quit in the gap between effort and results.

Scroll IV

YOU ARE UNIQUE

REFRAIN

I am nature's greatest miracle.

THE SPIRIT OF IT

After three scrolls about behavior, this one turns inward and addresses identity. Its message is that every person is one of a kind, with a combination of abilities no one else has ever had, and that imitating others is a waste of that uniqueness. The scroll pushes the reader to stop comparing, stop apologizing for being different, and treat their own capacity as something to be developed rather than doubted. It also insists that the natural gifts we are given carry a responsibility to use them.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- No one else has your exact mix of experience, ability, and perspective. Trade on it.
- Imitation caps you at someone else's ceiling. Originality has none.
- Your mind and body are capable of far more than you currently ask of them.
- Talent unused is a debt owed. Develop what you have been given.

IN PRACTICE

Stop selling like the top producer you admire and start selling like yourself. The client is buying you, not a script.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** Stop comparing your relationships, your home, or your path to anyone else's. Yours is the only one that fits you.
- **In sales.** Sell in your own voice. Clients trust a real person far more than a polished imitation of someone else.
- **In leadership.** Coach each agent to their strengths, not to a single mold. The best teams are made of originals, not copies.

Scroll V

URGENCY

REFRAIN

I will live this day as if it is my last.

THE SPIRIT OF IT

This scroll is about time and attention. It asks the reader to treat each day as complete in itself, with no yesterday to regret and no tomorrow to lean on. Regret over the past and anxiety about the future are both described as thieves of the only thing you actually have, which is today. The practical instruction is to pour everything into the present hours: every task, every conversation, every effort done fully rather than saved for later.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- Yesterday is gone and cannot be edited. Tomorrow is not promised. Today is the only working material.
- Work with the intensity of someone who knows the clock is running.
- Do not save effort, kindness, or courage for a better day. Spend them now.
- End each day empty, having given it everything.

IN PRACTICE

Ask yourself at noon: if this were my last workday, would I be proud of the morning? If not, the afternoon is where you fix it.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** Say the kind thing today. Make the call to the friend today. There is no better day than this one to do it.
- **In sales.** Work every appointment as if it is the only one on the calendar. Full presence is the rarest thing a client encounters.
- **In leadership.** Never let an important conversation with a teammate wait for a better time. The right time is the one you have.

Scroll VI

EMOTIONAL CONTROL

REFRAIN

Today I will be master of my emotions.

THE SPIRIT OF IT

This scroll addresses the fact that moods swing and results follow them. The reader is told that nature has its seasons and so do people, but that a person of purpose cannot afford to let weather decide the day. The scroll offers a set of counter-moves: when feeling one way, act deliberately the opposite. It also warns about the other side of the coin, the danger of arrogance when things are going well. Steadiness in both directions is the goal.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- Feelings come and go; your actions do not have to follow them.
- Respond to a low mood with the behavior of a high one. Action pulls emotion along behind it.
- Do not let success make you careless or failure make you passive.
- Read the moods of others with patience, because they are fighting the same battle.

IN PRACTICE

The mood you bring to the phone at 9 a.m. is a choice, not a forecast. Decide it before you sit down.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** Do not bring a bad day home as a bad mood. The people you live with did not cause it and should not carry it.
- **In sales.** A rude prospect gets the same calm, warm voice as a friendly one. Your composure is part of the product.
- **In leadership.** Your team reads your face before they hear your words. Stay level in a bad week and they will too.

Scroll VII

LAUGHTER AND PERSPECTIVE

REFRAIN

I will laugh at the world.

THE SPIRIT OF IT

The lightest scroll in tone and one of the most important. It argues that laughter is the antidote to taking yourself too seriously, and that most of what feels catastrophic today will be forgotten soon. The scroll gives the reader a mental phrase to reach for in both triumph and disaster, a reminder that this moment, whatever it is, will pass. Perspective is treated as a skill, not a personality trait.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- Laughter restores proportion. It shrinks problems to their real size.
- Most crises are temporary. Treat them that way.
- Do not let success inflate you or failure crush you; both are passing.
- Joy is contagious and it belongs in your work, not just outside of it.

IN PRACTICE

When a deal falls through, ask whether it will matter in a year. It almost never will. Then get back to it.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** Laugh together often. Shared humor is one of the strongest glues a relationship has.
- **In sales.** When you lose a deal, let it be funny by tomorrow. Lightness keeps you in the game for the next one.
- **In leadership.** Keep the culture light even when the numbers are heavy. A team that can laugh together can grind together.

Scroll VIII

MULTIPLYING YOUR VALUE

REFRAIN

Today I will multiply my value a hundredfold.

THE SPIRIT OF IT

This scroll is about goals and standards. Its core idea is that a person grows in exact proportion to the demands they place on themselves. Set small targets and you get small results. The scroll instructs the reader to set goals far beyond what feels reasonable, to raise the bar every time it is cleared, and to announce those goals so that pride will not allow retreat. It ties self-worth directly to the size of the challenge accepted.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- You grow to the size of the goal you set. Aim high enough that it changes you.
- Each time you reach a target, raise it. Standing still is the only real failure.
- Say your goals out loud. Public commitment closes the exits.
- Compare yourself only to who you were yesterday.

IN PRACTICE

Whatever your number is, double it and then plan the activity that would actually produce it. The plan is where growth lives.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** Raise the bar on how you show up for people, not just on how much you produce. Grow as a partner, parent, and friend too.
- **In sales.** Whatever your production goal is, set the activity plan that would produce double. Growth lives in the plan.
- **In leadership.** Set team goals that feel slightly unreasonable, then build the support that makes them possible. People rise to real challenges.

Scroll IX

ACTION

REFRAIN

I will act now.

THE SPIRIT OF IT

The ninth scroll is the hinge that turns everything before it into results. It states plainly that dreams, plans, and good intentions are worthless without action, and that procrastination is failure wearing a disguise. The refrain is meant to be repeated until it becomes reflex, so that the gap between deciding and doing shrinks to nothing. The scroll walks through fear, fatigue, and excuses and gives the same answer to each one.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- A plan not acted on is only a wish.
- Delay is the most expensive habit there is. It costs more than mistakes do.
- Fear shrinks when you move toward it. Waiting only feeds it.
- Action now beats a perfect plan later.

IN PRACTICE

When you catch yourself thinking about a call instead of making it, that is the cue. The thought is the signal to dial.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** Apologize now. Reach out now. The relationships that fade usually fade from delay, not from conflict.
- **In sales.** When you think about a follow-up, that is the signal to do it. The gap between thinking and dialing is where sales die.
- **In leadership.** Make decisions quickly and adjust openly. A team waits on a leader who waits.

Scroll X

GUIDANCE AND HUMILITY

REFRAIN

A prayer for guidance (this scroll has no repeated refrain).

THE SPIRIT OF IT

The final scroll changes form. Instead of a set of commands, it is written as a prayer, and it asks not for success but for guidance, strength, and the wisdom to keep going. It is a reminder that after all the discipline and effort, a person still needs humility, gratitude, and something larger than their own ambition. The tone is quieter, and it closes the book on a note of dependence rather than mastery.

CORE PRINCIPLES

- Ask for help. Self-reliance has limits, and admitting them is strength.
- Gratitude keeps ambition from turning hollow.
- Ask for opportunity and the courage to use it, not for outcomes to be handed over.
- Stay teachable. The person who thinks they have arrived has stopped growing.

IN PRACTICE

End the day by naming what went right. It keeps the grind from becoming the whole story.

HOW IT COMES TO LIFE

- **In relationships.** Ask for help from the people who love you. Letting them in is a gift to them as much as to you.
- **In sales.** Start the day with gratitude for the clients you already have. It changes how you speak to the ones you don't yet.
- **In leadership.** Stay teachable in front of your team. A leader who still asks questions gives everyone permission to grow.

The Ten Refrains

ONE LINE A DAY. SAY IT UNTIL IT IS A REFLEX.

SCROLL I

Today I begin a new life.

SCROLL II

I will greet this day with love in my heart.

SCROLL III

I will persist until I succeed.

SCROLL IV

I am nature's greatest miracle.

SCROLL V

I will live this day as if it is my last.

SCROLL VI

Today I will be master of my emotions.

SCROLL VII

I will laugh at the world.

SCROLL VIII

Today I will multiply my value a hundredfold.

SCROLL IX

I will act now.

SCROLL X

I will ask for guidance.

A Daily Prayer

IN THE SPIRIT OF SCROLL X

I do not ask for an easy road. I ask for the strength to walk the one in front of me.

I do not ask that the doors be opened for me. I ask for the courage to knock, and to knock again when no one answers.

Guide my words today so that they serve the people I speak with, and not only myself.

Keep me steady when the day goes well, so that success does not make me careless.

Keep me steady when the day goes badly, so that failure does not make me quit.

Remind me that the people I meet today are carrying burdens I cannot see, and let me treat each one with patience and warmth.

Help me to act and not to wait. Help me to finish what I start. Help me to leave nothing for tomorrow that belongs to today.

Give me a heart that laughs easily and a mind that keeps things in proportion.

Let me grow a little today. Let me be more useful tonight than I was this morning.

And when I lie down, let me be grateful for what was given, at peace with what was withheld, and ready to rise again.

Amen.

An original prayer written in the spirit of Scroll X. The book's own closing prayer is in your copy and can be read alongside this one.